

The Mongol Empire

The Mongols were made up of many nomadic tribes who lived in the grasslands of Central Asia. They were often at war with each other. In the early 13th century, these tribes were united under the leadership of the Mongol chief Genghis Khan. He formed a powerful army and conquered vast areas of Asia and Europe, creating one of the largest empires in history.

For centuries before the empire was established, the Mongols raided towns and villages in northern China. After uniting the Mongols, Genghis Khan had a huge and powerful army under his command. Turning his attention back to China, in 1211 Genghis launched a campaign against the Jin Dynasty, and by 1215, he had captured Beijing. Soon the Mongol army began pressing west, conquering territory across Central Asia and into Eastern Europe.

While their conquests were violent, the Mongols brought peace and stability to the regions they controlled. This was known as Pax Mongolica ("Mongol Peace"). The Mongols did not rule directly. The conquered kingdoms had to pay large taxes to the empire and in return were allowed to rule their own territories. The Mongol Empire reached its greatest extent under Genghis Khan's grandson, Kublai Khan. After his death in 1294 the empire went into decline.



GENGHIS KHAN ▲

Born as Temüjin in modern-day Mongolia, Genghis Khan (reigned 1206–1227) took his name (which means “universal ruler”) after uniting the Mongols in 1206. He was a fearsome warrior and brilliant military tactician who often succeeded in battle even when his armies were outnumbered.



SIEGE OF BAGHDAD

Led by Genghis Khan's grandson Hulagu Khan, the Mongols attacked Baghdad (in modern-day Iraq), the capital of the Abbasid Caliphate, in 1258. In a 13-day siege, the Mongol army killed hundreds of thousands of residents. Baghdad's famous library, the House of Wisdom, was also completely destroyed.